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Children's Conceptions of the Arts

HOWARD GARDNER, ELLEN WINNER, AND MARY KIRCHER

INTRODUCTION

The abilities of young children to perform creatively in the arts have been the focus of much recent attention.[1] Studies have revealed that the spontaneous speech of preschool children is often replete with similes and metaphors;[2] that effective teaching can inspire grade-school children to use language in a fluent and unusually sensitive manner;[3] and that the child artist, without educational buffeting, may often produce paintings of notable originality and visual attractiveness.[4] Even when more delimited tasks are posed, the preschool and primary school youngster often exhibits considerable skill. Children of these ages have, for example, succeeded in making metaphoric matches and in grouping paintings by style.[5] Often, however, the same child who can speak of an object which is "as soft as quiet" displays little conceptual understanding about art. Similarly, the young child who can look closely at two Impressionist paintings and detect fine textural differences between a Renoir and a Bonnard may reveal, when questioned, startling misconceptions about what a work of art is, how it is made, or what distinguishes it from a machine-made or a natural object.

What children know and do not know about the arts is a much neglected problem in the psychology and pedagogy of the arts. Indeed, there appear to be only two research traditions which impinge on this

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cluster of issues. The first, associated with the works of Piaget, Kohlberg, and their associates,[6] has clarified children's conceptions of many related topics, such as moral judgment, physical causality, and theories about thought. The clinical method[7] used by these investigators, and the stages of development they have uncovered, provide valuable background for the present research. However, except for the speculative writings of J. M. Baldwin,[8] none of these cognitively oriented investigators has focused on the arts.

The recent work by Ecker on "Children's Talk About Art"[9] is similarly instructive as regards children's approach to certain perennial aesthetic questions. However, Ecker has worked principally with older children, seeing them in group settings, and focusing on questions which presuppose an understanding of the basics of artistic production. Moreover, he does not provide statistics on the frequency of different conceptions and misconceptions among his target population. As a consequence, the developmental trends across ages, the depth of understanding of individual subjects, and the frequency of specific conceptions and misconceptions about art objects per se remain to be elucidated.

It may be asked why, if children's artistic productions are interesting and original, attention need be paid to their thoughts about the artistic process. Several considerations appear relevant. First of all, as he grows older, it is most probable that the young person's participation in the aesthetic world will be as audience member, perceiver, or critic; the appreciation of all art, and especially forms of modern art such as electronic music or abstract painting, demands understanding which both prevents misconstruals and enriches one's experience. If a child does not know that music is different from noise, that a painting of a horse is not the same as the photograph of one and is not necessarily superior to an abstract work, or that a poem can be more than a string of rhyming words, he or she can hardly be expected to respond in a meaningful way to a work of art.

A second consideration is pragmatic. Considerable effort and money is expended as school systems bus students to museums, parents pressure their children to watch a concert on television, and museums attempt to stage an educational exhibit. It is not known, however, whether most children are bored, superficially entertained, or deeply affected by such "cultural" exposures. And clearly the young child who is unaware that a painting is produced by an individual and that it need not faithfully depict a subject cannot fully appreciate an art

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museum. Unless those charged with aesthetic education have knowledge of the child's level of understanding of the arts, the value of their curriculum or exhibit is questionable at best.

Study of children's conceptions of aesthetics is equally crucial to education in the *making* of art: if children are not to be left wholly on their own to create, and if there is to be some form of explicit instruction, then the teacher must be cognizant of the kind of ideas the young bring to bear on these lessons. Finally, by shedding light on the child's personal experience with art works, one has an opportunity to help broaden or revise these experiences, and one can attempt to understand the relationship between attitudes about art and one's ability both to respond to and make works of art.

THE RESEARCH

Methods. To assess conceptions with respect to a broad range of topics and aesthetic media, interviews lasting between twenty and forty-five minutes were conducted with 121 children, an approximately equal number of males and females, drawn from both middle- and working-class families, and ranging in age from four to sixteen years. In the present report, responses will be analyzed exclusively in terms of age or "stage" level.

The general procedure involved bringing the child into a room, speaking with him briefly to put him at ease, and then indicating that he was to be shown a number of objects and to be asked his opinions on a number of topics. It was stressed that his own views were of interest, and that there were no "right" and "wrong" answers. Responses were tape recorded for subsequent analysis after permission had been obtained from the subject. The tape recording procedure was accepted readily by all subjects.

First the interviewer showed a work of art, read a poem, or played a recorded passage for the child. (The order of the works presented was counterbalanced across subjects.) The subject was then asked what he had seen or heard. Taking off from the subject's initial response, the interviewer then posed a variety of questions, such as "Where did it come from?" "What else might you call it?" "Did you like it?" "Do you think everyone would like it?" "Could you make it too?" The topics to be covered in the interview had been planned in advance, but the actual order of questioning was determined by the subject's responses to each question. That is, whenever the subject touched on a topic of interest to the study or made a remark which

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called for elaboration, the interviewer would pursue this area. Then, after the child's own views on the topic had been drawn out, the interviewer moved on to another topic. Across the total population, so many art works were displayed and topics covered that a comprehensive review is not possible in a single article. Accordingly, we will focus in this report on eight topics and on the medium of painting.

An open-ended clinical procedure was preferred to the closed series of a questionnaire because of our concern with the *reasons* which underlay specific factual responses. A closed-interview procedure would not have allowed sufficient freedom to probe unexpected and potentially revealing responses which emerged, nor would it have permitted flexibility in the order of posing questions. Conducting such an interview requires considerable training and practice, as one must avoid posing leading questions. For instance, it is unacceptable to ask a child "Who made this picture?" since the question already implies the answer "A person." Only if the question is phrased in a neutral way, such as "Where do you think it came from?" or, less acceptably, "How do you think it was made?" is one likely to elicit the information that the picture was made by a machine, or had already existed, or was a photograph. Achieving skill in these techniques is a lengthy process for which each interviewer was carefully trained and given supervised practice with at least one dozen pilot subjects.

Analysis of Protocols. After the session had been completed, the tape recordings were transcribed. Then each of the subject's answers was classified under that one of the eight topics to which it was most relevant. If, as was sometimes the case, the answer bore on more than one topic, it was simply reproduced under both headings. Despite the best efforts of the interviewers, not every aspect of each topic was touched upon (or dealt with by the subject in other than an "I don't know" manner). As a result, some children's views could not be determined on selected issues. In general, however, the average subject provided responses on at least two aspects of each of the eight topics.

In the review of findings below, subjects' answers have sometimes been characterized as "right" or "wrong"; an explanation of this procedure is warranted. Even though it is risky to speak of right and wrong in the area of aesthetics, it did seem useful to divide the questions into those for which an informed adult consensus exists and those for which it does not. As a result, if a subject indicated that a poem had to rhyme, that a painting was not different from a photograph, or that anyone could hang his works in a museum, these response were

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considered erroneous. On the other hand, in the case of questions about *which* art work was better, or whether two works of art might have been produced by the same individual, no such classification was made. It bears emphasis, again, that we were in any case less interested in the "rightness" of an answer than in the underlying rationale produced for it. After all, a subject might indicate (correctly) that works of art differ in value, only to indicate that value is always determined by majority vote.

RESULTS

Overall Trends. Subjects were initially grouped in two ways: by age and by the level of maturity reflected in their dominant responses. There was a sufficiently great overlap between chronological age and developmental "stage" to allow the collapsing of these two groupings in this report. That is, *immature* responses were usually found among the 54 four- to seven-year-olds; *intermediate* or *transitional* responses were typically found among the 51 eight- to twelve-year-olds; and *mature* responses were found among the 16 fourteen- to sixteen-year-olds. The responses at each stage shared certain basic characteristics briefly summarized below.

The most fundamental misconceptions about art were typically found among the youngest subjects. When asked to identify works, they tended to name the represented object rather than the medium of representation. When asked about the medium directly, they often gave answers which were *concrete* and *mechanistic*. That is, the child focused on the mechanics of producing a work, the machinery and actions involved in production, and the technical limitations, such as the size of the canvas or the amount of paint available. The immature responses also tended to be animistic — paintings might be thought to just begin, or to arise out of paper and paint. Frequent *legalistic* responses revealed an overwhelming preoccupation with rules: what one is allowed to do or paint, the punishments for improper procedures, the conventions, loopholes, and deceptive strategies available in our community. (One cannot alter part of a painting and claim credit for it, said a five-year-old, because "if the artist had made it and he sees there's a difference he might kill the person who changed it.")

The middle age group was a transitional one — the children were in the process of breaking away from primitive conceptions and moving towards those of the oldest group. Thus, their responses were often a mixture of mature and immature views. Certain characteristics were,

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however, specific to this age group. Art was rather rigidly seen as a *striving toward realism,* the success of which was judged by proper authorities rather than by individual reactions. Preoccupations with *fairness* had taken the place of the excessive legalism of the youngest group. Finally, both responses and interpretations of questions tended to be extremely *literal* — the subjects did not generalize beyond the most concrete interpretation of the question, and they failed to consider the possible, focusing instead on the here-and-now.

The oldest subjects were capable of a less mechanistic, more *complex* and *cognitive* view of art. Their attitudes were not as rigid as those of the two younger groups. But they were not totally free of misconceptions: in general, they were tolerant to the point of extreme relativism in the area of artistic judgments; they revealed little awareness of the formal requirements of a work and had not completely broken away from a view of art as a mechanical process or an attempt at literal realism. These adolescent subjects did, however, demonstrate a basic understanding of the difficulty involved in artistic creation, the various directions which works and styles can take, the properties of different media, and the relation of art to the public.

The topics to be discussed below fall into three categories: (1) the production of works of art (sources, training, and the occasion for artistic creation), (2) identities of works (definitions, stylistic features, and formal properties), and (3) evaluation of works (criteria of quality and the location and manner in which works are displayed). For each topic, the qualitatively different conceptions of the three groups will be compared.

I. *Production of Works (The Work as a Human Creation)*

A. *Sources.* The youngest group displayed considerable misconceptions about the origin of a work of art. When presented with a painting and asked to explain where it came from, less than 10 percent *volunteered* that "it was painted by a person." Most responses revealed a lack of interest in the original human source of the work: "all pictures are made at the factory," they came from a "store," a "book," a "school," a "camera," or a particular geographical time and place in history, possibly one suggested by the content of the work. Although the human origin of a painting was not apparent to these children, two-thirds of the subjects eventually conceded, when pressed, that paintings were made by people. The remaining third, however, seemed

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to lack even an *implicit* knowledge of a human source. Some offered animistic explanations: stories have always existed, songs are made by God, paintings "just begin." The rest described mechanistic origins, simply listing the materials involved in production, often with no verb supplied and no implication of an artist who uses these materials; for example, music just *comes* from an "organ, piano, banjo, or radio clock."

Children in the youngest group often considered painting and writing to be performable by animals as well as humans. Although only one-half of the group actually *affirmed* that animals could paint, the reasoning behind both negative and affirmative answers was similar. Some children believed that animals could not paint because "they don't have hands," "their claws get in the way," or "they can't hold a brush." Others believed that they could, precisely because they do have hand substitutes such as feet, tails, or trunks: "A tiger puts a pen in his mouth, an elephant uses a trunk to write." In almost all cases, painting and writing were mechanically defined as the wielding of a brush or pen, and few indicated awareness of any cognitive or perceptual skill involved.

Among the subjects of the intermediate group, two-thirds expressed on their own an understanding of a human source while the rest still focused on the materials involved in production, with no indication of a human artist. One quarter of the subjects insisted that animals could paint just like humans. Of those who denied this proposition, all offered cognitive rather than physical reasons, that is, animals "are not smart enough."

Only at adolescence was the source of art works universally seen as both a human and a cognitive one. Many of the subjects of the oldest group described the artistic process as painting from one's mind, or from one's imagination, and showed an appreciation for the personal and expressive nature of art. Although adolescents said that animals could paint, they meant this in an entirely different way from the younger subjects. No one pretended that animal art would resemble human art: it would be messy, hard for people to relate to, qualitatively different: "Maybe a chimp painting is art to a chimp, but not to me."

B. *Training*. Because the subjects of the youngest group viewed artistic activity in a matter-of-fact vein, their modal attitude was that works could be created by anyone, or at least by any adult. Only a few said that artists, or a special group of people, make art, and some

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miscellaneous, peculiar responses were also found: "only a young man" or "only the richest man" can paint. One six-year-old epitomized the mechanistic bias of his group, claiming that anyone can make a picture, but "machines make prints and this is better than people making things."

No child of this group embraced the concept of inborn ability or a proclivity toward artistic excellence. If painting is easier for some, it is only because they are older, have watched others doing it, or have had more lessons. When considering how long it takes to be good, almost every child prescribed a specific time period, ranging from one hour to twenty years. (Often they differentiated between media: some art forms, such as stories, were seen as easy, and others, such as poems, as very difficult.) The modal view expressed, however, was that only a short period of training was necessary. A few felt that training was irrelevant: "you pick up a crayon and draw," "you just trace another picture," and to play music you just "use your hands" or "touch the keys." Among the four- and five-year-olds, almost all felt that *anyone* could teach, while the majority of six- and seven-year-olds were beginning to acknowledge the necessity of some form of guidance by artists or "special" people.

Among the intermediate group, two-thirds of the children had abandoned the belief that anyone could have painted the works used in the interview. The modal response revealed an appreciation for the difficulties of artistic creation — it takes a long time to become good, and the help of a qualified teacher is vital in order to acquire skill. Although the importance of training was recognized, only 30 percent revealed awareness of the notion of inborn ability.

In contrast, the subjects of the oldest group all acknowledged the complexity of artistic creation — they affirmed that both natural ability and intensive training are critical in order to produce "good" art.

C. *Occasion for Artistic Creation.* The youngest children believed that art could only be created at a specific and narrow time and place ("outside in the morning"), and that a model must be present for the artist to copy. Despite the fact that their *own* drawings are often nonrepresentational, these subjects explicitly stated that the painter needs a model to "see if it looks good," that is, to match up the painting to reality. Without a model, the painter cannot paint, unless another picture is copied; indeed 30 percent of the six- and seven-year-olds volunteered a Malraux-like[10] view that pictures are made by "looking at another painting and making it a little like it."

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When asked explicitly whether it was possible to draw a picture of something that cannot be seen in the world, these same children contradicted their previous response. Two-thirds of the subjects in the youngest group replied affirmatively to this question and cited examples like "a house that isn't there," or mythological fairy-tale figures. Some had difficulty conceiving of things that cannot be seen and could only describe them as "little things," "nothing," or things that can be seen "if you have invisible glasses in your eye." The contradiction between the necessity of a model and the possibility of painting what cannot be seen was not an unusual pattern at the youngest stage. The majority of these pre-operational[11] subjects seemed to be entertaining two opposing views and were unaware of, or unconcerned with, any conflict between them.

The intermediate group of subjects also defined a restricted time and locale for artistic creation. When queried about where art could be made, they frequently interpreted this question to mean where was this *particular* painting done. Even though 75 percent no longer felt that a model was necessary, most subjects responded by specifying a time and place appropriate to the subject matter being displayed.

Upon further questioning it became clear that these subjects typically conceived of art as a form of literal realism. A frequent reason given for why a model was not necessary was that the artist could remember a previous one. Contradictory responses by the same child abounded: for example, "You can draw a giraffe if you never saw one if you heard people talking about one," but, skipping to another medium, "if you're writing about what you see on a nice day, you couldn't write it in the middle of the night."

Asked whether one could paint something that cannot be seen in the world, subjects of the intermediate group responded affirmatively. But their literalism led almost all of them to misinterpret the question. Things that cannot be seen in the world were exemplified by "the moon" or "the stars." They thus revealed an inability even greater than that of the younger subjects to conceive of things that cannot be seen, such as imaginary, inner worlds. This tendency is consistent with findings that the five-year-old has but a vague sense of the distinction between real and imaginary objects, whereas the ten-year-old, having recently developed such a distinction, displays a preoccupation with realism.

The oldest subjects entertained the mature view that paintings could be either representational or imaginative and subjective. Their re-

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sponses were characterized by a tolerance of many different ways and occasions for creating art rather than by the rigid and often contradictory views of the two younger groups.

II. *Identities of Works (The Work as a Symbolic Unit)*

A. *Definition of Works — Knowledge of Media.* Like the sources of art, the medium of a work was irrelevant and sometimes totally unnoticed by the youngest subjects. When asked to identify a work, they named the represented subject matter: a picture of a horse was identified as a horse rather than as a painting, and a poem about money was identified as "money-rich people" or "a cent." When probed, 50 percent of the four- and five-year-olds conceded that the "horse" was also a "picture"; most six- and seven-year-olds added this information of their own accord, but it remained secondary to the primary identification. Apparently, younger children did not think abstractly in terms of *classes* of things; the subject who defined a picture as a "horse," or even as "paper," responded in a literal, concrete, and nongeneric way. The painting was confused with either the physical materials of which it was composed or with its subject matter. The medium was but a transparency through which representations of the world could be glimpsed.

It should not be surprising, therefore, that the youngest group also exhibited fundamental misconceptions concerning the properties of specific media. A photograph and a painting were believed by some to be the same thing. A poem "could be words, or music, or just pictures." Music was not distinguished from the noise of natural or machine-made objects: the sounds of tapping and a waterfall were identified as music, as was a car going by "if people like it" or "if you want it to be."

Subjects of the intermediate group responded equally to the subject matter and the medium of a work: half of the group first identified a work by its content but then added spontaneously that it was a picture; the other half identified a work first by its medium. A more clearly defined sense of the properties of various media was found among this group. Eight-year-olds were beginning to narrow their definition of music; for instance, neither the sound of tapping nor a car going by were identified as music, but a waterfall was, because "drops fall at different times on things." By age ten and eleven most subjects demonstrated a more mature knowledge of different media

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even though (like adults) they were more often clearer about what could *not* be a property of a particular medium than what *could* be: "music is not noise, music sounds nice"; "tapping is not music, you have to have the melody."

The oldest group focused entirely on the medium when identifying a work, while the content remained incidental. The medium, with all the formal possibilities it holds for symbolization, had acquired an independent existence.

B. *Stylistic Features.* Children at the youngest age level were blind to individual style. They revealed no understanding of the existence of an artist's individual "handwriting." (A person cannot make a perfect copy of another painting simply because the copier would not "have colors like that.") Almost half felt that the abstract and traditional works shown them could well have been painted by the same person. The key difference between the two was perceived to be subject matter rather than style. More idiosyncratic reasons were also offered, such as, "there was no one else to paint the other painting." Those who believed them to be made by different artists gave reasons totally divorced from style: "the artist would have gotten too tired if he had painted both," or "he couldn't have done two at a time." Typical responses regarding how one could tell who did a particular painting likewise ignored individual style and cited *external* ways of discovering the artist: "ask someone," "you saw him do it," or "maybe one artist did every painting in the world."

When asked which painting they preferred, four- and five-year-olds chose an abstract over a representational painting because of its "pretty colors," "nice design," or imagined represented subject matter. They had less trouble than older subjects finding an identifiable content in an abstract work (such as toys), perhaps a further indication of a weaker distinction between real and imaginary objects. In contrast, more six- and seven-year-olds preferred the traditional work because the particular one shown was more realistic, or because it was bigger and seemed to be therefore a more impressive achievement. Just as photos were better than paintings because they were more lifelike, so real objects were deemed better than representations because they could be manipulated and seen in three dimensions. ("A real shell has an inside," while "a picture is just a copy.") Pictures were characterized as "fake," "flat," or "soft," even though "prettier" than natural objects, whereas real things were described as "hard," "alive," and "real."

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Slightly more than half of the middle group demonstrated some understanding of the notion of individual style. An expert can tell who did a certain painting, they stated, by looking at the *way* it is painted. Less sophisticated responses were still given, however, although with much less frequency. Two-thirds of the intermediate-age children again expressed a strong preference for the realistic work and for real objects rather than mere "copies" of them.

Subjects of the oldest group had a firmly grounded concept of family resemblances between paintings by the same individual, a likeness which has nothing to do with content but rather with the way in which the medium has been used by the artist.[12] Like most of the younger subjects, the oldest ones preferred the traditional work to the abstract and a real object to a picture of one. A few, however, did prefer the abstract work, and for well-motivated reasons: it was viewed as more creative, original, and imaginative because an individual can see what he or she wants in it and draw different meanings from it. One fourteen-year-old said that a painting was better than a natural object because "everyone can enjoy it," and two sophisticated subjects of this age said that it was impossible to say *which* was better since it depended on "what you want it for." On the whole, however, the replies of all ages indicated first and foremost a concern for realism in paintings and a curiosity about reality, a desire to perform operations on things in the world and to understand how they work. Empirical curiosity and concern for function seemed to take precedence over more "formal" or "pure" aesthetic enjoyment.

C. *Formal Properties.* On several issues probed in this study, there was less development across age. Children of all ages lacked a notion of formal, aesthetic properties which determine whether a work of art is finished, just as they also lacked such a notion when it came to questions of aesthetic judgments. Thus, when the youngest subjects considered how the artist might know when a painting was complete, they most frequently cited the physical limitations of the materials as the determining factor: "when he fills up the paper," or "when it is dry." Other external criteria were also offered as deciding factors: when the artist is "tired" or "bored," "at ten o'clock," "when the guy who wants to buy tells him to stop," or "when everything is copied." Only a few six- and seven-year-olds had a vague intuition about subjective guidelines for determining when a work is complete (the artist can "just *tell*," a painting "*looks* done," or the artist's "mind tells him when to stop"), and even they were unable to bolster these statements

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with reasons having to do with the formal characteristics of a painting.

When considering whether a part of a work could be altered and credit claimed for it, four- to seven-year-olds demonstrated no awareness of the work as an integral whole. Additions or deletions were readily proposed. The modal view was that one could change a painting and get credit for either part or all of it. Irrespective of the view adopted, mechanistic and legalistic considerations were primary: "You can if you have a special eraser," or you can't because "the colors would run" or "some people wouldn't like it."

Subjects of the older groups did not reveal appreciably greater sophistication on these issues. Extrinsic reasons continued to be the modal response on the question of when a work is finished: "when the canvas is covered," "when the scenery all around him is completed," or when the poet "runs out of things to say." Again, only a very few offered the intuitively correct response that the painting just "seems right," but they were unable to explain what they meant. This is, of course, a complex problem, and it is not surprising that even the oldest children were unable to take it further.

Most subjects of the two older groups believed that one could change a work of art (primarily because it is physically possible to do so), but they felt that it would be unfair to claim credit for it because "it wasn't yours." Their focus, thus, was on the moral aspect: ethical ideas of fairness had developed, but no one considered the aesthetic issues involved.

III. *Evaluation of Works (The Work and the Community)*

A. *Criteria for Evaluation.* Distinct differences across age were found when subjects thought about how one evaluates a work of art, although no child demonstrated any awareness of formal properties which make one work better than another. Among the youngest group, there was no consensual view about who decides what is good. Responses varied widely from extreme relativism (if two people disagree, "both are right"; a painting is good "because I love it"; or "anyone decides") to pluralism ("they should vote") to submission to inappropriate authorities ("mommies and daddies" decide, "the boss" decides). As children approached age seven, there was an increasing tendency toward endorsement of older people as authorities. Universally, however, subjects of the youngest group proclaimed all opinions to be equally valid and seemed unaware of the contradiction between

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this view and the appeal to the authority of the majority or, in some cases, of the interviewer.

The intermediate subjects generally appealed to the authority of expertise — people trained in art are those best qualified to judge it. "People who have thought longer have better opinions." (This respect for the expert differs, of course, from the younger child's respect for less appropriate authorities.) Unlike the younger subjects, and in line with their appeal to authority, most middle-group children did not believe that all opinions carried equal weight. But illogical explanations for this view revealed a basic confusion about what might make one opinion more valid than another. (Not all opinions were equally valid "because some like one more than another.")

The oldest group consistently displayed an extreme relativism. There was an insistence on the validity of all opinions, which were seen as not more than matters of taste. They proclaimed that "there is no correct way to play music" and that it is impossible to determine what is right in an aesthetic dispute since what is "good" depends on what one likes. This raises an interesting question, itself susceptible to investigation: the older children had lost what the intermediate ones seemed to be approaching, the notion of an appropriate authority and the granting of different weights to different opinions.

B. *The Public Display of Paintings.* Four- and five-year-olds evinced considerable misinformation concerning the relation of art to the public. Paintings, they thought, were seen primarily in stores. Only two thought that one went to a museum to see a painting, and a few others thought that paintings were to be seen in factories, libraries, or schools. The modal response of six- and seven-year-olds, however, was that one went to a museum, and only a minority cited a store or factory.

Four- and five-year-olds believed either that anyone, or certainly any adult, could hang his or her paintings in a museum. Half of the six- and seven-year-olds also believed this, whereas the remaining half thought that only "special people" were eligible. When asked who decides whether a painting can be exhibited, an authority figure was universally cited, with no awareness of the contradiction between this belief and the belief that anyone can hang a work in a museum. Inappropriate authorities were most often cited (the boss, the landlord, or the president), and no notion of the opinion of the expert was revealed.

Both older groups demonstrated a more mature understanding of the relation of art to the public: only famous or good artists can show

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their works in a public museum, and it is the museum owner who makes the decision. No subject, however, mentioned anything about the expert's opinion.

IMPLICATIONS AND CONCLUSIONS

Our study reveals the existence of a number of qualitatively different views about the arts over the course of childhood. Although all children of the same age may not be at the identical stage on each issue, one can clearly discern broad patterns at the three principal age, or stage, levels. Moreover, the general characteristics of these conceptions — legalistic and mechanistic at the earliest stages, literally realistic and concrete at the next, cut across a wide range of subject matters and issues. There is, furthermore, no evidence that these stages of thought are taught or imitated: rather, they appear to be spontaneous constructions at a certain developmental stage. In all, discussion of conceptions of "the arts" seems legitimate.

Before conclusions can be accepted as generally valid, however, the reliability of the methods used must be tested. We adopted the clinical method of Piaget because it is designed to uncover what the subject believes and how he conceives of an object even if he or she has difficulty putting it into words. While, of course, it cannot be proven that children are ignorant of what they fail to verbalize, the clinical method does yield a greater reliability in response than closed questionnaires or directed inquiries (which can easily be manipulated to bring about one or another conclusion). This is so because the interviewer can gently probe with "follow-up" questions, offer seductive counterexamples to test the tenacity with which a view is held, and allow the child's responses to determine the direction and wording of subsequently discussed issues. The widespread agreement across subjects, and the consistency of responses about art with children's views of other topics,[13] lend further credibility to the findings.

It is important to specify to what extent children's thinking about the arts reflects the way in which they think about the world in general. For the most part, findings about the arts seem to mirror the trends uncovered by Piaget, Kohlberg, and others in the cognitive-developmental tradition. For instance, confusions about the precise relationship between human, mechanical, and natural events abound in early childhood, while the adoption of a relativistic yet not value-free approach is found only among sophisticated subjects. But to a certain degree the arts *do* pose problems which seem to be non-generalizable ones: first,

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diverse media are involved and each may entail its own traits and misconceptions; second, most children in our society really have little direct experience with the fine arts, while, in contrast, their familiarity with the physical and moral universes is already extensive; third, what experiences they do have are often mediated by mass technology — that is, they see reproductions of paintings or watch a concert on television; fourth, parental prejudices about art, as either mere recreation on the one hand or exalted activity for an elite on the other, are often very marked; and, finally, there is the all-too-prevalent and socially biased feeling that the arts are too sophisticated and too remote for the untrained individual to grasp. Certain beliefs about art seem to have no direct analogy in other areas, such as the view that animals can paint or write poems, that one may tamper with art objects, or that one can recognize commonality in diverse productions because of a shared handwriting or style. Separate study of conceptions of the arts accordingly seems justified.

A comment should be made about two kinds of contradictions common to the children's responses, one of which is symptomatic of general cognitive trends, the other again specific to the arts. The contradictions among a particular child's responses are evidence of a cognitive deficiency which cannot be overcome until the child is at the level of operational thinking.[14] But the contradictions between what subjects say and what they do (for example, their insistence that a model must be present while, in their own work, such rarely is the case) seem to be an especially nefarious product of the great distance in our society between the fine arts and one's own playing and artistic activities.

A number of implications can be drawn from this study. First, it is important from a developmental standpoint to determine how children think about the arts. Otherwise, one risks devising exercises or drawing conclusions about children's artistic activities which are untenable. In addition, it is desirable to understand the source of misconceptions. The present study indicates that, in addition to a substantial universal component in children's artistic conceptions, there is also a fair degree of prejudice and even of foolishness: the latter could be readily corrected by informed parents and teachers or by experience which exposes children to the sources of art works or the means by which aesthetic judgments are reached and justified. Indeed, the study underlines the necessity of humanizing the artistic experience so that children can more readily connect their own products with adult artistic activity.

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It is not our view that the various misconceptions held by children should be instantly corrected. That would be impossible, in any case, and quite probably some of these mistaken ideas are harmless, and others (like the insistence on literal realism in middle childhood) perhaps a necessary stage en route to a more sophisticated view. Clearly, what is primary in the arts is the way children see and make inferences and what they can accomplish in diverse media. But some misconceptions may be destructive, and it is useful for the teacher to be aware of these and to correct them whenever possible. One cannot, for instance, be sensitive to style if all one sees is subject matter. One cannot appreciate abstract works if one insists on fidelity to the "real world." All works of art are not equally good, and one's experience is impoverished as long as this view is uncritically embraced. Paintings are different from photographs, and they are not made in factories by machines. Such beliefs may interfere with a child's artistic experience, unjustifiably setting the arts apart. And if steps are not taken during childhood to expose these false notions, to bring about a more veridical and humanistic view of the arts, the adolescent or adult may have become so alienated from the arts that, as in much of our society today, the whole domain seems as distant as a star, as fearful as a dread disease, as mysterious as the speaker of a dead language.

Notes

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2. K. Chukovsky, *From Two to Five* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1968); H. Gardner, *The Arts and Human Development* (New York: Wiley, 1973), Ch. 4.

3. K. Koch, *Wishes, Lies and Dreams* (New York: Chelsea House, 1970).

4. H. Read, *Education through Art* (New York: Pantheon, 1945); H. Gardner, *The Arts and Human Development,* Ch. 5.

5. H. Gardner, "Metaphors and Modalities: How Children Project Polar Adjectives onto Diverse Domains," *Child Development* 45 (1974): 84-91;

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"The Development of Sensitivity to Figural and Stylistic Aspects of Paintings," *British Journal of Psychology* 63 (1972): 605-15.

6. See, for example, J. Piaget, "Piaget's Theory" in P. Mussen, ed., *Carmichael's Manual of Child Psychology* (New York: Wiley, 1970), I, 703-32; L. Kohlberg, "Stage and Sequence: The Cognitive-Developmental Approach to Socialization," in D. Goslin, ed., *Handbook of Socialization* (New York: Rand McNally, 1969).

7. Cf. J. Piaget, *The Child's Conception of the World* (London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1929).

8. J. M. Baldwin, *Genetic Theory of Reality* (New York: G. P. Putnam's, 1915).

9. D. Ecker, "Analyzing Children's Talk about Art," *Journal of Aesthetic Education* 7 (January 1973): 58-73; "Teaching Art Criticism as Aesthetic Inquiry," *New York University Education Quarterly* 3 (Summer 1972): 20-26.

10. Cf. A. Malraux, *The Voices of Silence* (Garden City, N.Y.: Doubleday, 1963).

11. On pre-operational thought, see B. Inhelder and J. Piaget, *The Early Growth of Logic in the Child* (New York: Norton, 1964).

12. H. Gardner, "Style Sensitivity in Children," *Human Development* 15 (1972): 325-38.

13. J. Piaget, *The Child's Conceptions of the World.*

14. On operational thought, see J. Piaget, "Piaget's Theory."

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